

Prambanan

An ninth-century temple complex in Indonesia on the borders of Yogyakarta and Central Java, Prambanan is the largest Hindu temple in ancient Java. It was probably built to mark the return of the Hindu Sañjaya dynasty to power in Central Java after nearly a century of dominance by the Buddhist Sailendra dynasty. The Sañjaya king Rakai Pikatan founded it c.850 CE to honour Lord Shiva, and subsequent kings expanded it into a compound of three zones. The outer zone was a large open space; the middle zone contains 224 small, identical shrines; the central, holiest zone is surrounded by a square stone wall with a gate at each of the four cardinal points. The three main *trimurti* (shrines) within this walled compound include the Shiva shrine at centre, on top of a terraced and richly decorated plinth. Reliefs illustrating stories from the *Ramayana* epic continue on the terraces of the Brahma and Vishnu shrines. Though it is complex, Prambanan nonetheless conforms to Hindu temple design requirements in following a geometric grid dominated by the imposing 47-metre (154-ft) central building.

